him in person. He replied, ‘If you have the time, both of you come over for dinner.’

My son was cock-a-hoop about the prospects of meeting Ratan. That evening, the two of them spoke for around three hours. I listened silently as he gave my son snapshots of his extraordinary life journey. When it was over, overwhelmed by what I had heard, my irrepressible urge to know more, and with an equal eagerness for the world to know his life story, I asked Ratan, ‘Have you ever considered writing your autobiography?’ He replied, ‘I can’t do it, you may think of it, should you choose to.’ Thus began an effort to write the story of one of the most celebrated personages whose life holds many inspiring lessons for future generations.

But it soon dawned on me that I had bargained for more than I thought I was committing to, in every sense of the term, and the task never became any less daunting.

I was determined to undertake the project only as an independent research work, without taking any assistance, financial or otherwise, from Ratan, lest the work should lose its credibility. A supported work would have rendered the life story of a man so worthy of admiration and emulation less valuable, as it might then, in public perception, have lost its objectivity.

But guarding the project’s independence meant that I would have to dig deep into my savings to put together a research team and bear the related expenses. This included extensive travel both within India and across the world, from the desert town of Albuquerque in the US (to meet some of Ratan’s colleagues) to the remote Kenyan town of Magadi (to meet the local Masai chief whose tribe benefitted from the social schemes of the Tata Magadi chemical plant). I interviewed stakeholders, Tata veterans, Ratan’s friends and associates, more than 135 in all.

These challenges soon got dissolved, however, in the excitement of the work. The overarching desire to guard its independence made me laugh off situations that may have perturbed many—for instance, the problem that I faced when an interviewee postponed a meeting in San Francisco. There was no room in any affordable hotel near the area where I was to have the meeting at very short notice, compelling me to stay in a hotel built in 1901 for about $60 a night, with daredevil bedbugs that crawled all over the bed in disdain, obdurately unafraid to die.

The research too was exponentially difficult. As Ratan shares a common ancestry with the Tata founder, Jamsetji, his story had to begin many years